

PREMIUM

Pre-Departure Checklist

From visa in hand to landing in the United States

2-4 weeks before departure

- Confirm your visa is stamped in your passport and check the details (name, visa type, validity dates) are all correct - report any error to the issuing post immediately
- Check your passport's remaining validity - many travelers aim for at least six months beyond their planned stay as a safe margin; airlines sometimes enforce this at check-in even when it's not strictly required for entry
- Book or confirm flights and accommodation if you haven't already
- Arrange travel insurance, including medical cover - the U.S. has no public healthcare access for visitors and treatment costs can be very high
- Notify your bank and card providers of your travel dates and destination to avoid cards being blocked for "unusual activity"
- Refill and organize any prescription medication - bring it in original packaging with the prescription/doctor's note, especially for controlled substances

The week before

- Print or save digital copies of: passport photo page, visa page, DS-160 confirmation, flight itinerary, accommodation confirmation, and your U.S. point of contact's details
- Share your itinerary and emergency contacts with someone at home
- Check entry requirements for any transit countries on your route, separately from the U.S. visa
- Download offline maps and a translation app if useful for your destination cities
- Check your airline's baggage rules and any item restrictions

Day of travel

- Arrive at the airport with extra buffer time - international departures typically recommend 3 hours before an international flight
 - Keep your passport, visa, and printed documents in your carry-on, not checked luggage
 - Have your U.S. address and purpose of visit ready to state clearly and simply
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At the U.S. port of entry

Arriving with a visa doesn't automatically grant entry - a Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officer makes the final admission decision at the port of entry. This is a normal part of the process, not a sign anything is wrong.

- Be ready to briefly restate your purpose of visit and planned length of stay, consistent with what you told the consular officer
- The officer sets your authorized stay (recorded electronically as your I-94) - this is what actually controls how long you can stay, not your visa's expiry date
- Check your I-94 record online after entry (i94.cbp.dhs.gov) to confirm the exact date you must depart by

Keep your admitted-until date top of mind

Overstaying even a valid visa's associated authorized stay has serious consequences for future U.S. travel. Mark your I-94 departure date somewhere visible the moment you land.